

Google Maps API keys, step by step

For the Shero Home Food ordering page. It takes about 15 minutes. You need a Google account and a payment card (for billing).

You will create 2 keys:

Key	What it does	Google API to enable	Goes into
Server key	Turns a map pin into an exact street address, and address search into a pin	Geocoding API	GOOGLE_MAPS_API_KEY
Browser key	Shows Google's map (with satellite view) on the order page	Maps JavaScript API	GOOGLE_MAPS_BROWSER_KEY

Why two keys: the browser key can be seen by anyone who opens the page. It is locked to your website, so nobody else can use it. The server key never leaves the server.

1 Open Google Cloud Console

1. Go to <https://console.cloud.google.com/>
2. Sign in with the Google account the business will own. Use a company account, not a personal one.
3. If asked, accept the Terms of Service and pick your country.

2 Create a project

1. At the top left, click the **project picker** (next to "Google Cloud").
2. Click **New Project**.
3. Project name: `Shero Home Food` . Leave Location as it is. Click **Create**.
4. When it's ready, open the project picker again and **select "Shero Home Food"**. Check that its name shows in the top bar before you continue.

Direct link: <https://console.cloud.google.com/projectcreate>

3 Turn on billing (required by Google Maps)

1. Go to <https://console.cloud.google.com/billing>
2. Click **Link a billing account**, or **Create account** if you have none. Enter the business card details.
3. Make sure the billing account is linked to the **Shero Home Food** project.

Google Maps gives a **free monthly usage allowance** for each API. Testing and a small shop's orders usually stay inside it. See the current prices at <https://mapsplatform.google.com/pricing/>

Recommended: set a budget alert. Go to Billing → **Budgets & alerts** → **Create budget**. Set an amount, for example \$10 a month, and keep the email alerts at 50%, 90% and 100%. This means a bill can never surprise you.

4 Enable the two APIs

1. Open console.cloud.google.com/apis/library/geocoding-backend.googleapis.com
It shows **Geocoding API**. Click **Enable**.
2. Open console.cloud.google.com/apis/library/maps-backend.googleapis.com
It shows **Maps JavaScript API**. Click **Enable**.

Or use the menu: ☰ → **APIs & Services** → **Library**, search each name, and click **Enable**. Check that the top bar still shows the Shero Home Food project.

5 Create key 1: the server key

1. Go to <https://console.cloud.google.com/apis/credentials>
2. Click + **Create credentials** → **API key**. A key appears (it starts with `AIza...`).
3. Click **Edit API key** (or the key's name in the list) and set:
 - **Name:** Shero server key
 - **Application restrictions:** **None** for now. Once the bot runs on its real server, change this to **IP addresses** and add that server's IP.
 - **API restrictions:** choose **Restrict key** → tick only **Geocoding API**.
4. Click **Save**. Then click **Show key** and copy it.

6 Create key 2: the browser key

1. On the same Credentials page, click + **Create credentials** → **API key** again.
2. Click **Edit API key** and set:
 - **Name:** Shero browser key
 - **Application restrictions:** **Websites**. Click **Add** and enter:
`https://shero-order-bot.local.lt/*`
When the bot moves to its own domain, add that too, for example `https://order.yourdomain.com/*`
 - **API restrictions:** **Restrict key** → tick only **Maps JavaScript API**.
3. Click **Save**. Then copy this key too.

New keys and changed restrictions can take **up to 5 minutes** to start working.

7 Put the keys into the bot

Option A: the `.env` file (in the project folder). Fill in these two lines:

```
GOOGLE_MAPS_API_KEY=Aiza...your server key...
GOOGLE_MAPS_BROWSER_KEY=Aiza...your browser key...
```

Option B: Admin dashboard → Settings → Maps. Paste each key into its box and save.

Then ask for the server to be restarted so it picks up the keys.

Never send the keys in chat, email or screenshots. Paste them only into `.env` or the Admin Settings page.

8 Check that it works

1. On WhatsApp, send **new link** to the bot and open the menu link.
2. Add a dish, go to the address step, and tap **+ Add a new address**.
3. The map should now be **Google's map**, not the OpenStreetMap one. Move the pin, and the street address should fill in with the house number.

! If something goes wrong

What you see	Fix
The order page still shows the old (OpenStreetMap) map	The browser key is missing, or the server was not restarted. Or the page's address is not in the key's Websites list; check the exact spelling and the <code>/*</code> at the end.
"This page can't load Google Maps correctly"	Maps JavaScript API is not enabled, billing is not linked, or the website restriction does not match the page address.
Address does not fill in when moving the pin	Server key: Geocoding API is not enabled, or the key is restricted to the wrong API. The bot then falls back to the free OpenStreetMap lookup.
"REQUEST_DENIED" or "billing not enabled"	Go back to step 3 and link billing to the Shero Home Food project.
It worked on loca.lt but not on the new domain	Add the new domain to the browser key's Websites list (step 6).

Without any Google keys, the bot still works: it uses the free OpenStreetMap map and lookups, which are less accurate.